

Competitor Analysis for Uday Sangle's Campaign – Sinnar Constituency (2026)

Introduction

The Sinnar assembly constituency in Nashik district has traditionally seen contests between heavy-weight local politicians. Uday Sangle, a former youth activist who turned politician, contested the 2024 assembly election as the **Nationalist Congress Party (Sharad Pawar faction)** candidate and came second to the NCP (Ajit Pawar) candidate **Manikrao Kokate**. As the campaign prepares for the next electoral challenge, understanding the main competitors – their profiles, strengths, weaknesses and recent controversies – is crucial. This report synthesises available information up to June 2026 with citations from credible sources.

Political Landscape of Sinnar

- **Historical results.** The Sinnar seat was held by **Rajabhau Waje** of Shiv Sena in **2014** before **Manikrao Kokate** of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) won in **2019** and retained the seat in **2024** ¹. According to the 2024 election results, Kokate received **138,565 votes (57.36 %)**, while **Uday Sangle** obtained **97,681 votes (40.43 %)**; the victory margin was **40,884 votes** ². The results highlight both the incumbent's strength and the challenger's significant voter base.
- **Key communities.** Sinnar's electorate includes Maratha, OBC (Mali, Vanjari, Dhanger and other groups), Scheduled Castes, Muslims and other minorities. Farmers and co-operative society members also play an influential role due to the constituency's agrarian economy.
- **Dominant issues.** Voters often raise concerns about irrigation, crop prices, unemployment, transport infrastructure and corruption in local bodies. High-profile criminal cases or political controversies can influence voter sentiment.

Main Competitors

1 – Manikrao Kokate (NCP – Ajit Pawar faction)

Aspect	Evidence & details	Analysis
Experience & positions	Kokate has been elected MLA for Sinnar five times since the 1990s. He served as a cabinet minister in the Maharashtra government and has switched parties multiple times (Indian National Congress, NCP, Shiv Sena, Congress, BJP and back to NCP). After winning two terms with NCP, he joined Shiv Sena when denied a ticket; he returned to Congress in 2009, moved to BJP and lost in 2014, then re-joined the NCP and won in 2019 and 2024 ³ .	Kokate's long career and frequent party switches show political adaptability but can cause trust issues. His ministerial experience gives him deep networks in the state bureaucracy.

Aspect	Evidence & details	Analysis
Electoral performance	In 2024 he won 138,565 votes (57.36 %) against Uday Sangle's 97,681 votes (40.43 %) ² . He previously defeated Sangle in the 2019 election (narrow margin) and regained the seat after losing to Rajabhau Waje in 2014 ¹ .	Strong personal vote bank and control over local co-operatives; ability to mobilise resources and voters even after switching parties.
Strengths	1. Deep local network – decades of MLA service provide strong ties with village leaders, co-operative societies and administrators. 2. Government clout – experience as cabinet minister helps deliver state funds and projects to the constituency. 3. Personal following – despite party switching, many voters support him personally ³ .	These strengths make him a formidable opponent and major power centre in Sinnar politics.
Weaknesses	1. Controversies – Kokate was convicted in a 1995 cheating and forgery case related to a housing scheme for the economically weaker sections. The sessions court upheld a two-year sentence; the Bombay High Court suspended the sentence but refused to stay the conviction ⁴ . Kokate resigned as Sports and Youth Affairs Minister after the conviction was upheld ⁴ . 2. Anti-incumbency – after multiple terms, voters may seek change. 3. Party switching – frequent party changes may reduce ideological credibility ³ .	The conviction and resignation have damaged his public image. Any by-election or further legal trouble could erode support.
Digital presence	Kokate's social-media activity is limited; his campaign relies more on offline networks. Local news coverage shows his statements and events but he lacks a strong online brand.	Opportunity for Uday Sangle to dominate digital space and attract youth and urban voters.

Implications for Uday Sangle

- Highlight Kokate's **legal issues** and **anti-incumbency** sentiment. Stress the need for transparent, corruption-free leadership.
- Capitalise on Kokate's limited digital presence with a robust online campaign targeting young voters and urban areas.
- Present Sangle as a clean, stable alternative contrasting Kokate's frequent party switches.

2 – Rajabhau Waje (Shiv Sena – Shinde faction & current MP)

Aspect	Evidence & details	Analysis
Background	Waje belongs to a Maratha political family . He served as MLA for Sinnar from 2014 to 2019 and is currently Member of Parliament from Nashik (elected in 2024) ⁵ . The article notes he led farmers' agitations and his panel took control of the Sinnar Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC) from Kokate's supporters in 2023 ⁵ .	His farmer-centric activism and successful takeover of the APMC make him a champion of agrarian issues. Being MP gives him statewide visibility.
Electoral history	Waje won the 2014 assembly election (Shiv Sena) and lost to Kokate in 2019. He then contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election from Nashik and won ⁵ .	Waje's shift from assembly to parliament indicates ambition beyond Sinnar. If he enters state politics again, he could split anti-Kokate votes.
Strengths	1. Farmer connection – known for leading farmers' movements and addressing agrarian distress ⁵ . 2. Family network – part of a Maratha political family with long-standing influence. 3. Control of APMC – his faction gained control of Sinnar APMC, reducing Kokate's hold ⁵ .	He appeals to agrarian and Maratha voters. The APMC victory shows organisational strength and ability to wrest local institutions from rivals.
Weaknesses	1. Split focus – as MP he must balance national duties with local political campaigns. 2. Party faction – belongs to the Shinde faction of Shiv Sena; the Thackeray faction may run its own candidate, splitting votes. 3. Previous loss – lost the 2019 assembly election, indicating vulnerability ¹ .	Waje's return to Sinnar politics could divide opposition votes or attract anti-incumbent voters depending on his strategy.
Digital presence	Active on social media; posts updates on parliamentary work and local events.	His online presence appeals to youth and urban voters but lacks hyper-local campaigning compared with Uday Sangle's potential.

Implications for Uday Sangle

- Position Sangle as the **authentic local alternative** – emphasise his continuous focus on Sinnar while Waje pursues national politics.
- Build alliances with disgruntled Shiv Sena (Thackeray faction) and other groups to consolidate anti-incumbent votes.
- Address agrarian issues prominently to compete with Waje's farmer credentials.

3 – Other Potential Competitors

- **Shiv Sena (Thackeray faction).** They may field a candidate to regain relevance after the 2019 defeat. Their vote base overlaps with Waje's; a three-cornered race could benefit the incumbent if the opposition splits.
- **Independent / smaller parties.** Local sarpanches or independent candidates can garner a few thousand votes, particularly in villages where they have personal networks. While unlikely to win, they can influence the margin.

Opportunities for Uday Sangle

1. **Strong grassroots network.** Although he lost in 2024, **Uday Sangle secured over 97,000 votes** ², demonstrating a substantial base. His support comes from youth, rural workers and those dissatisfied with the incumbent's style. Sangle's wife, **Sheetal Sangle**, previously served as Nashik Zilla Parishad president and supported Eknath Shinde's faction of Shiv Sena during the party split ⁶. This gave the family cross-party connections and rural influence.
2. **Anti-corruption narrative.** Kokate's conviction for cheating in an EWS housing scheme ⁴ provides a potent narrative for a campaign centred on honesty and accountability.
3. **Digital engagement.** Both Kokate and Waje have limited digital strategies. Uday Sangle can build an aggressive online presence – using Instagram, Facebook, WhatsApp groups and local language video content – to mobilise youth and first-time voters. Highlighting local development, real-time problem solving and transparency can differentiate him from older politicians.
4. **Alliance building.** Forging alliances with smaller parties, farmers' groups and influential village heads can consolidate votes. Outreach to Shiv Sena (Uddhav Thackeray faction) supporters, who oppose the Shinde group, may expand Sangle's base.
5. **Issue-based campaigning.** Focus on irrigation, farm prices, local employment, road repair and anti-corruption. Showcase personal involvement in village disputes, youth sports programmes and social services to strengthen his community reputation.

Conclusion

Manikrao Kokate remains the dominant figure in Sinnar politics due to his long service, resource networks and vote bank. However, his legal troubles ⁴ and anti-incumbency sentiment offer an opening for challengers. Rajabhau Waje's re-entry to state politics could split opposition votes or create a triangular contest. To succeed, **Uday Sangle** must position himself as the clean, energetic alternative. A well-researched digital and grassroots campaign, combined with alliances and clear messaging on local issues, can convert his existing support into a winning coalition.

¹ Maharashtra Assembly Election Results 2024, Sinnar Constituency: Candidates, Parties, Past Results, Winners, Losers, And Vote Shares

<https://www.freepressjournal.in/elections-2018/maharashtra-assembly-election-2024-sinnar-constituency-candidates-parties-past-results-winners-losers-and-vote-shares>

2 **Sinnar Assembly constituency - Wikipedia**

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sinnar_Assembly_constituency

3 **Manikrao Kokate - Wikipedia**

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Manikrao_Kokate

4 **EWS housing scam case: Bombay HC suspends ex-Maharashtra minister Manikrao Kokate's two-year sentence; bail granted, conviction stands | India News - The Times of India**

<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/india/ews-housing-scam-case-bombay-hc-suspends-ex-maharashtra-minister-manikrao-kokates-two-year-sentence-bail-granted-conviction-stands/articleshow/126077653.cms>

5 **Rajabhau Waje - Wikipedia**

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rajabhau_Waje

6 **NCP (SP) expels Uday Sangle of Sinnar and Sunita Charoskar of Dindori | Nashik News - The Times of India**

<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/nashik/ncp-sp-expels-uday-sangle-of-sinnar-and-sunita-charoskar-of-dindori/articleshow/125039857.cms>